Heritage As Composer Authenticity: A Poietic Approach Towards Sounds With Heritage-Related Quality In Electroacoustic Music Composition.

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ABSTRACT

In seeking an artistic voice and identity, I am interested in applying sounds that relate to my heritage as the foundation of musical composition. The term *heritage* denotes "*valued objects and qualities such as cultural, traditions… that have been passed down from the previous generations; a special or individual possession*" (New Oxford Dictionary, 2010). Heritage encompasses the cultural-inheritance and the life-experience of an individual. It is associated with an individual intrinsically and plays a direct part in authenticity of a creative work. I found in the domain of electroacoustic music, the composer is offered the opportunity to obtain sounds that relate to him or her on a more personal level. For example, the compositional materials can be sounds from the composer's family, childhood, special events, memories, and sounds from the habitual lands that are meaningful to the composer.

First of all, in adapting sounds relating to my heritage as electroacoustic music composition, instruments and sounds that suggest heritage-related quality are considered. From an Asian-Pacific perspective, native instruments such as the New Zealand Maori instruments, and the Asian traditional instruments are mostly made from natural organic substances. For example, the *Koauau* (New Zealand Maori) is made of wood or bone; the *Dizi*, *Xiao* (Chinese), the *Daejeum* (Korea), and the *Shakuhachi* (Japan) are made of bamboo; Tuaroria (New Zealand Maori) and *Muye* (Chinese) are tree leafs used as wind instruments. In the case of the Taonga Puoro, natural organic instruments are produced within the concept of 'individualizing one's own instrument'. For instance, the length of a custom-made Koauau is measured to the length of one's palm. Therefore, the sounds of the instrument are unique to the individual. John Dewey in *Arts as experience* suggests that aesthetic appreciation is inherently connected with the experience of making. From a poietic stand point, the concept of 'making your own unique instrument' provides an opportunity for composers to fully engage with the process of sound making. In addition, the instrument is unique to the instrument producer or performer. The paradigm of making one's own instrument is commonly adapted by composers such as Akio Suzuki, Phil Dadson, and Ajay Kapur et al as the exploration of their artistic voices. The sounds from the custom-made instrument and the performer/producer imply *surrogacy of the self*[1] (composer/performer/instrument maker) within the sounds. Moreover, the use of natural organic substances and the appreciation on natural beauty suggests a harmony between the human and the lands. In ancient Chinese philosophy, the material force and substance of the *five agents* (water, fire, wood, metal and earth) provide beneficial support for all things: "[the five agents] are first used to become an embryo and later for growth and support. … the physical form gets its support everyday, every day the material force enjoys its flourish, and principle attains completion everyday. These things are received as one is born, but as one continues to live for a day, one keeps receiving them for a day…." (Chan, 1963).

A pragmatic approach is adapted within the context of the work. Organic substances from nature such as bamboo, wood, soil, and stones are investigated as the basis of my organic instrument production. Organic sounds from the native landscapes are explored in both concrete and abstract fields with the aid of technology. In response to intuition with adapting sounds from the learned and the primitive schemas, my approach is to explore the inherent quality of organic substances and organic sounds that contains a human inheritance. The findings from the pragmatic

[1] I borrowed the term from Gerardo Dirie's ACMC 2011 presentation *Surrogates of Self: Exteriorising Organic Behaviour in Sound*.

aesthetic approach may support composers, performers, students and teachers who are interested in cultivating the aesthetic individuality through producing musical composition in the similar contexts.

REFERENCE

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